



LISETTE POOLE GONZÁLEZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Yusimi Castellano Moya, 58, cooks with charcoal, using plastic as kindling, in the kitchen of her apartment in Santiago, Cuba.

Floridians Ship Staples to Aid Cuban Kin Hurt by Blockade

This article is by David C. Adams, Andrea Zarate and David Ovalle.

MIAMI — People in Cuba are enduring food shortages, near-constant blackouts and suffocating heat.

For many, the only relief comes in packages from relatives hundreds of miles away in Miami.

As the island nation faces economic collapse under the U.S. oil blockade, South Floridians are rushing to ship boxes stuffed with canned meats, bags of rice and beans and other staples to hungry relatives. They are also sending

mosquito nets, flashlights, fans and loosefitting nightgowns for coping with insufferable nights. Some pay off-the-books couriers known as “mulas,” or mules, who fly to Cuba to deliver goods or envelopes of American cash.

Jorge Smith, 64, who left Cuba for Miami four years ago, has been shopping for a stronger solar-powered generator for his daughter and her 5-year-old son in Havana. With electricity ever more fleeting, the 60-watt machine he bought and shipped them months ago no longer suffices.

“They only have two hours grid power a day,” said Mr. Smith, an

Demand Intensifies as Energy Crisis Grows

Uber driver who, like many Cuban Americans, struggles to pay his own bills in an increasingly unaffordable Miami.

While he is deeply opposed to the Cuban government, Mr. Smith doesn't agree with the blockade. “By cutting off the oil, they cut off the life of the people,” he said. “It's the people who suffer.”

Cubans have long relied on rela-

tives in the United States, who today can turn to informal couriers, multiple shipping companies in Miami and Amazon-style shopping sites that arrange deliveries to the island.

But demand has intensified as Cuba's Communist government struggles to contain a catastrophic energy crisis. The island has all but run out of fuel for local transport, and its aging power stations are unable to keep its electrical grid running.

Oil shipments from Venezuela, Cuba's longtime benefactor, were already dwindling before the

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Strange Turns When a Whale Was Stranded

By JIM TANKERSLEY and JENNY GROSS

POEL ISLAND, Germany — On a mid-April day off Germany's northeast coast, a Peruvian spiritual author and motivational speaker named Sergio Bambarén slipped into the Baltic Sea. He plunged his head into the chilly water and began singing to a humpback whale.

Mr. Bambarén is not a marine biologist. He had just arrived in Germany at the request of one of a pair of millionaires who were funding a private effort to save the humpback. The whale, nicknamed Timmy by the news media, had become stranded in March, and public officials had tried and failed several times to free him.

Mr. Bambarén, who said he was the veteran of five humpback rescues, sang underwater as he touched the young whale. Timmy, he said, sang back: “He immediately felt we were trying to help him.”

At the time, it felt as if an entire country was, too.

Crowds flocked every day to a sleepy lane on Poel Island, where they watched the whale lie half-submerged and mostly motion-



PHILIP DULIAN/DPA, VIA ASSOCIATED PRESS

Stuck in the Baltic, Timmy united Germany in hope. Rescue efforts came. So did finger-pointing.

less in the water. Thousands more tuned in via livestream. People flooded online message boards and local government meetings, pleading for the whale's rescue.

In that first month, Timmy seemed to bring out the best in the German public.

By the end, he had brought out something else entirely.

Two cravings of modern West-

ern life are for community and for conspiracy. In the two-plus months after he first wandered into the Baltic, Timmy satisfied both.

The whale became a tabloid star and a magnet for marine-mammal-adjacent social media influencers. He freed himself but got stuck again. His superfans turned on the experts who had

tried, and failed, to set him loose, armed with elaborate theories about why the government wanted him dead. Government officials did, in fact, briefly consider killing him — for humanitarian reasons, they said — but decided against it.

Eventually, the officials allowed a rescue attempt by a private

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Watchdog Is Steamrolled By Industries It Regulates

Purge at Agency Overseeing Prediction and Crypto Firms, Some Tied to Trumps

By SHARON LaFRANIERE and DAVID YAFFE-BELLANY

WASHINGTON — Last fall, a high-stakes struggle unfolded inside the red brick walls of an obscure federal agency.

Three companies — each with ties to the Trump family's business empire — needed the Commodity Futures Trading Commission to bless their ambitions in the white-hot field of prediction markets.

A growing portion of the agency's portfolio, prediction markets allow Americans to bet on everything from whether the United States will take over Cuba to what color tie President Trump will wear next. The moneymaking opportunities were breathtaking, but the companies' practices were causing a stir.

Senior career officials worried about whether Crypto.com was treating small bettors fairly. They feared that a second firm, Polymarket, did not have strong enough protections against fraud. A third, an offshoot of the crypto firm Gemini, had yet to pass the agency's required review to open for business.

Despite these concerns, Caroline D. Pham, then acting chairman of the commission, and her senior counsel intervened to help the firms get what they wanted, according to people familiar with the situation who spoke on condition of anonymity for fear of repercussions.

By Christmas, the agency had put two top officials who had raised questions about the companies on leave, barred them from the office and placed them under

internal investigation. Three other senior officials who had enforced laws involving cryptocurrencies — another industry linked to the Trumps — suffered the same fate.

None of those officials were told what they had done wrong. But current and former agency staffers said in interviews that the commission's work force took away a clear message: Don't cause trouble for those industries.

The suspensions were just one of many ways in which the C.F.T.C., the primary regulator of a specialized sector of the financial markets, has been mowed down by the powerful business interests it is supposed to oversee, a New York Times investigation found.

In the past 16 months of the

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JASON ANDREW FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Commodity Futures Trading Commission in Washington.

Israel Sidelined As U.S. Takes Control on Iran

By DAVID M. HALBFINGER and RONEN BERGMAN

JERUSALEM — In the run-up to the Feb. 28 attack on Iran, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel was not only in the Situation Room with President Trump, he was leading the discussion, predicting a joint U.S.-Israeli strike could very well lead to the demise of the Islamic Republic.

Just a few weeks later, after those sanguine assurances proved inaccurate, the picture was starkly different. Israel was so thoroughly sidelined by the Trump administration, two Israeli defense officials said, that its leaders were cut almost entirely out of the loop on truce talks between the United States and Iran. On Saturday, Mr. Trump said the two countries were close to a deal, but he provided few details. [Page 13.]

Starved of information from their closest ally, the Israelis have been forced to pick up what they can about the back-and-forth between Washington and Tehran through their connections with leaders and diplomats in the region as well as their own surveillance from inside the Iranian regime, said the two officials. Like others for this article, they spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive matters.

The banishment from the cockpit to economy class has potentially significant consequences for Israel, and especially for the prime minister, who faces an uphill re-election battle this year.

Mr. Netanyahu has long sold

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Trump Keeps Pushing Plans People Dislike

By LUKE BROADWATER

WASHINGTON — By pretty much any estimation, President Trump had a very bad week.

New poll numbers showed his approval rating had hit a second-term low. Gas prices were high and inching higher heading into Memorial Day weekend. And his grip over Republican lawmakers began slipping after he proposed a pair of deeply unpopular spending items, prompting an unusual revolt from the Senate.

When faced with such a backlash ahead of midterm elections, many politicians would pivot, redirecting their focus to issues they are on stronger footing with.

But Mr. Trump has decided to double down, presenting himself as politically all-powerful even in the face of indications that he is not.

Over the years, Mr. Trump has often appeared to have an air of invincibility. He survived assassination attempts and won re-election despite being under multiple criminal indictments. He has successfully exacted retribution on many a perceived enemy. Now, with less than three years left in office, he seems comfortable burning whatever political capital he has in order to leave his legacy, even if it drags his party down in the process.

Rather than abandoning his plan for a \$1.8 billion fund to reward allies who claim they

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A Secret Spot No Longer

Residents on “Australia's prettiest street” are having to coexist with hordes of tourists posing for the perfect shot in a seaside town.

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ARTS & LEISURE

Steadfast in Steering the Met

Peter Gelb, the general manager of the New York opera house since 2006, says he is staying put amid a budget crisis and a changing arts landscape.

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Enjoying an Upswing

With her popular mystical podcast and a lauded return to Broadway in “The Rocky Horror Show,” Rachel Dratch is finally getting her due.

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SUNDAY BUSINESS

Life Lessons Outside a Costco

In Los Angeles, a middle-age skateboarder finds a thriving community in a big-box parking lot, where just showing up is a victory.

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SUNDAY OPINION

Noah Shachtman

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